

Lesson 17

Case Study: Crisis Communication



Warm-Up

- What would you do if your company website suddenly stopped working during a product launch?
- Who would you call first, and what would you say?



Role-play

Case Study: Crisis Communication at Tech Innovations Inc.

Background:

Tech Innovations Inc. experienced a crisis when a software update caused major system failures for several key clients, leading to downtime and complaints.

Crisis Situation:

- The update released on Friday resulted in significant disruptions, prompting immediate action.
- Customer service received a high volume of calls from concerned clients.

Team Meeting: Management held an emergency meeting on Monday with all department heads.

Meeting Highlights:

- **CEO:** Acknowledged the crisis and its potential impact on reputation.
- **Product Development Lead:** Briefed on technical issues and fix timeline.
- **Customer Support Head:** Discussed client concerns and emphasized empathetic responses.
- **Sales Director:** Suggested strategies to maintain client relationships.

Key Outcomes:

- Commitment to open communication with clients, including updates and compensations.
- Formation of a crisis management task force.

Analysis Questions:

1. What signs indicated a crisis?
2. How effective was the team meeting communication?
3. Why is employee involvement important in communication at Tech Innovations Inc.?
4. What improvements could enhance their response plan?

Discussion Questions:

- What best practices should organizations adopt for effective crisis management?
- How can companies create a proactive crisis communication strategy?
- How can leaders promote open communication during crises?
- How should companies balance transparency with positive messaging in crises?
- What are the long-term effects of poor crisis communication on reputation, and how can this be addressed?



Practice

A. Fill-in the Blanks Speaking Activity

Instructions: Work in pairs. Fill in the missing words using the vocabulary provided. Then, practice the conversation aloud using a clear and professional tone.

urgent	damaged	apologize	looking into	update	resolve
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Lena: Hi Mark. I just got an _____ message from a client. Their order arrived, but several items were _____.

Mark: Oh no, that's not good. Thanks for letting me know. I'll start _____ it right away.

Lena: Thanks. Can you give me an _____ in about an hour?

Mark: Sure. I'll check the packing list and talk to the team.

Lena: We need to _____ this quickly. It's a first-time client.

Mark: Understood. Please _____ to them on our behalf. I'll get back to you soon.

B. Multiple Choice Speaking Activity

Instructions: Read each crisis scenario and choose the best response (A, B, or C). Then, in pairs or groups, discuss why you chose your answer and practice saying it out loud with a natural tone.

Scenario 1: System Error

A client calls and says your company's system isn't working. What do you say?

- A. Yes, it happens sometimes. Try again later.
- B. We're aware of the issue and are working to fix it now.
- C. That's not my department. Call someone else.

Scenario 2: Delayed Delivery

Your team finds out that a shipment will arrive two days late. What do you tell the client?

- A. We apologize for the delay and are doing everything we can to speed it up.
- B. You'll get it eventually, don't worry.
- C. That's not our fault.

Scenario 3: Wrong File Sent to Client

You realize your team sent the wrong file to an important client. What should you say in an email or call?

- A. Sorry about that. Please find the correct file attached.
- B. You opened the wrong one.
- C. I don't know what happened.

Scenario 4: Negative Social Media Post

Someone posted a complaint about your service online. What is a professional first step?

- A. Ignore it. It's just one person.
- B. Reply politely and offer help.
- C. Argue in the comments.

Scenario 5: Power Outage During a Meeting

You're leading an online meeting when suddenly there's a power outage and the call drops. When you return, what do you say?

- A. Sorry about that — we had a power issue. Let's continue where we left off.
- B. That wasn't my fault. My internet is terrible today.
- C. Let's just cancel the meeting."



Production

ROLE-PLAY

1. Work in pairs
2. Each pair receives a crisis scenario (see options below).
3. Your task is to:
 - Discuss what happened
 - Plan how to respond
 - Role-play a conversation with a manager, client, or colleague
4. You must use professional crisis communication phrases. After 5–10 minutes of preparation, groups act out their role-plays.

Crisis Scenarios

- A shipment of products arrived late and damaged.
- A team member accidentally sent a sensitive document to the wrong client.
- A system crash delayed all client orders for three hours.
- A public complaint about your company was posted on social media.
- The wrong invoice was sent to a client with incorrect pricing.

Useful Phrases:

1. We sincerely apologize for the inconvenience.
2. We're working on a solution and will keep you updated.
3. Let me explain what happened.
4. Here's what we can do to fix the problem.
5. We understand your frustration and take this seriously.
6. The issue has been reported, and we are resolving it as fast as possible.
7. Can we offer a discount/credit/free service as an apology?

Example Conversation

Emma: Hi Leo, the client just called. They received an invoice with the wrong amount.

Leo: Oh, I'm really sorry about that. I'll correct it immediately and send the updated version.

Emma: Thanks. Please also apologize to the client in the email.

Leo: Of course. I'll explain the mistake and offer to answer any questions.

Emma: Good. Please keep me informed once it's sent.

Leo: Will do!

Discussion

- What was the most difficult part of the situation to handle?
- How did your team show responsibility and professionalism?
- How could the situation be prevented in the future?



Key Vocabulary

Word/Phrase	Use	Example
We apologize for the inconvenience.	To say sorry in a professional way.	We apologize for the inconvenience caused by the delay.
We are currently working on it.	To show that you are solving the problem.	The technical team is aware and we are currently working on it.
Thank you for your patience.	To politely recognize the customer's waiting.	Thank you for your patience while we fix this issue.
We take full responsibility.	To accept fault professionally.	We take full responsibility for the mistake and are correcting it.
The issue has been escalated to [department].	To say the problem has been sent to a higher level.	The issue has been escalated to our IT department for urgent resolution.



Wrap-Up

Crisis doesn't create character, it reveals it. — Denis Leary

What do you think is most important when speaking during a crisis—speed, honesty, or calmness? Why?